DEFYING THE ODDS

Breakout artists from Jammu & Kashmir



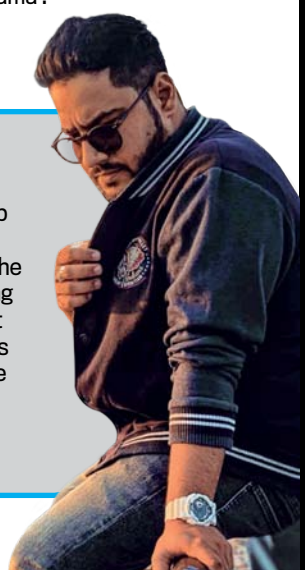
BHAU

Rohit Singh Bhau is a Jammu-based musician and guitarist with two albums—*Phir Se Qareeb* (2018) and *Aadataan* (2021)—to his credit. Love, heartbreak and youth's crossroads are all his forte.



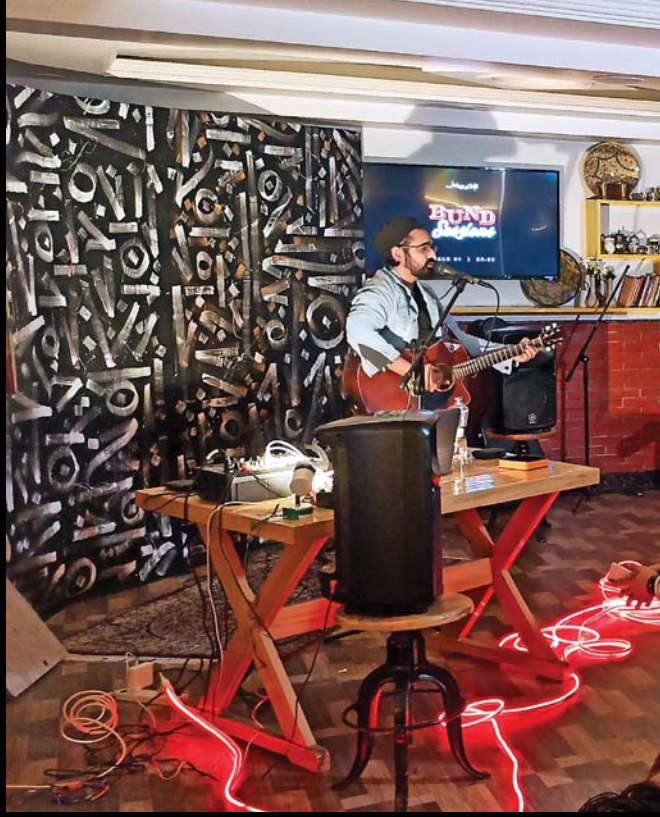
QAFILAH

One of Kashmir's most exciting hip-hop talents, Arif Farooq a.k.a. Qafilah was born and raised in Srinagar. In the last five years, he has released several hit singles like 'Lost Shikara' and 'Safarnama'.



SHEN B

Jammu-based hip-hop artist Shayaan Bhatt came to the fore when he put out 10 tracks during the 17-month Internet clampdown in J&K. His popular tracks include 'LockDown' and 'Fankaar'.



MUSIC

Kashmir's New Songbook

Young Kashmiri musicians are finding their voice in a new live venue in the Valley

Ahmer Javed was still in school when he first heard 50 Cent's 'In da Club' in a Kashmiri internet café. Though taken in by the 'good life' at first, Javed soon came to see that '50 Cent' or 'Fiddy' was only a persona, one that the artist Curtis James Jackson III wore. Digging into hip-hop history, listening to artists like Tupac Shakur and Eminem, Javed began to realise an obvious truth—the genre, ever since its inception, had given a voice to the marginalised sections of society. "They all have their stories and it's something you have to ask yourself: what is *your* story?" says Javed whilst speaking to INDIA TODAY.

Together with artists like Ali Saifuddin and Yawar Abdal, Javed, 26, is translating his experiences into poetry, verse, rhythm and melody, making formidable a new wave of Kashmiri musicians. Understandably, some of the songs coming out of the Valley now reflect the region's political turmoil and its aftermath in the mental health of the Kashmiri people. "If you've lived